



Exploring EFL Teachers' Roles in Metacognitive Writing Instruction

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Abstract ;

The present article seeks to examine the pivotal roles EFL teachers play in fostering metacognitive awareness and writing development among their students. Drawing on recent research findings, they highlight teachers' metacognitive awareness, their instructional practices, and their influence on students' writing performance. The review of the literature indicates that EFL teachers act as facilitators, models of metacognitive thinking, scaffolders, motivators, and feedback providers. However, teachers still encounter challenges such as limited professional development opportunities and curriculum constraints. The paper concludes by advocating for sustained institutional support and targeted training to empower EFL teachers in effectively implementing metacognitive writing instruction.

Article info

Received

November 27.2025

Accepted

January 12.2026

Keywords

- ✓ *EFL teachers' roles*
- ✓ *Metacognitive awareness*
- ✓ *Metacognitive strategies*
- ✓ *Metacognitive writing instruction*

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1. Introduction

The increasing interest in metacognitive strategies in education has directed attention to their potential in English as a Foreign Language (EFL) writing instruction. Oxford (1990) defined metacognitive strategies as *“actions which go beyond purely cognitive devices, and which provide a way for learners to coordinate their own learning process”* (p.137). Metacognitive strategies help EFL students plan their writing process, monitor their progress consciously, and evaluate the efficiency of the final product, so improving both the process and the outcome of writing (Qin et al., 2022). In this case, students take greater responsibility for their writing and enhance their self-reliance.

Numerous studies on metacognition and writing have been conducted. For instance, Xia (2017) conducted a study that explored metacognitive strategies in EFL writing instruction. The findings revealed that metacognitive writing instruction is effective, and extensive metacognitive knowledge allows students to use suitable strategies *“to monitor their writing process and products to achieve successful writing”* (p.163). Moreover, this study focuses on teachers' roles in attentively implementing instructional tasks and procedures by motivating students through questionnaires,

group discussions, think-alouds, and cue cards. Furthermore, teachers should act as facilitators, cognitive modellers, scaffolders, assistants, and coordinators.

In another study of writing instruction based on metacognitive strategies for vocational college students, Lv and Chen (2010) explored the impact of metacognitive strategy training on students' writing production. The study emphasised the implementation of the three categories of metacognitive strategies, as classified by O'Malley and Chamot (1990): planning, monitoring, and evaluating. The experimental treatment demonstrated the efficiency of training in metacognitive strategies on students' writing outcomes. In addition, this study emphasises the importance of teachers' roles in training students to self-plan, self-monitor, and self-evaluate their writing processes.

Zadeh and Behrouzi (2020) conducted a third study on the role of teachers' metacognitive awareness on language learners' knowledge of grammar and critical thinking skills. The results showed that metacognitive teachers are effective classroom managers who believe in cooperative learning. They work purposefully and help learners to progress in their learning process through modelling and explicit teaching of metacognitive strategies.

To sum up, the former studies emphasize the teachers' roles in guiding students toward self-regulation and strategic competence in writing.

2. Metacognitive Writing Instruction (MWI)

Metacognitive writing instruction, as an approach in the educational context, involves implementing metacognitive strategies—planning, monitoring, and evaluation—to regulate students' metacognitive awareness and improve their writing performance. Flavell (1979) defines metacognition as: "*thinking about one's own thinking*" (p. 906). Metacognition plays a crucial role in helping students as writers monitor and regulate their abilities and reflect on the writing process. This process involves a variety of stages such as planning, writing, revising, and editing (Flower & Hayes, 1980).

Applied to writing, metacognition involves three essential components: planning, monitoring, and evaluating. According to Chamot et al. (1999), planning is a vital step to becoming self-controlled. It is an

effective opportunity for learners to think attentively before starting any learning task. According to Oxford (1990), planning a learning task enables learners to arrange their language acquisition efficiently and

effectively.

According to Chamot et al. (1999), monitoring is a continuous process through which students regulate their understanding, the writing product, and its development. Once the writing assignment is complete, students can evaluate their final products for further refinement (Rivers et al., 2020). Evaluation as a metacognitive strategy is a worthy opportunity to regulate students' writing.

3. EFL Writing Teachers' Metacognitive Awareness

Within the scope of teaching English as a Foreign Language (EFL), teachers' metacognitive awareness is exceptionally significant in scaffolding students' writing process. Previous research emphasises the impact of teachers' metacognitive awareness on the development of positive teaching and learning outcomes. A supportive learning environment can be promoted to help learners reflect critically on their cognitive processes and strengthen their writing performance (Zhang & Zhang, 2019). EFL teachers with high

metacognitive awareness can adjust their strategies and reflect on their practices. Besides, they can successfully teach throughout their professional careers. Thus, enhancing teachers' metacognitive

awareness is an essential component of effective teaching and ongoing professional development.

4. EFL Teachers' Metacognitive Instructional Roles

EFL teachers play a crucial role in metacognitive writing instruction by coaching and training students to become metacognitively aware of their own writing processes. Indeed, EFL teachers' metacognitive roles in writing include a variety of facets. They can be facilitators, models of metacognitive thinking, scaffolders of metacognitive awareness, motivators, and feedback providers.

4.1 Facilitators of Metacognitive Instruction

Learning to write efficiently requires students to understand the various aspects of the writing process. This understanding can be possible when students are empowered with the necessary skills for effective writing. As noted by Harmer (2001), *"teachers are ideally placed to provide comprehensible input since they know the students in front of them and act appropriately to them"* (p.66). Teachers can help students practise writing accurately and gain positive experiences throughout the writing process. *"The teacher is no longer the giver of knowledge, the controller, and*

the authority, but rather a facilitator and a resource for the students to draw on" (Harmer, 2001, p.57). The teacher's role as a facilitator promotes the use of metacognitive strategies during the writing process.

Writing stages such as planning, organising, drafting, revising, and evaluating are parts of the writing process. Teachers' clear and efficient explanation of the latter parts can facilitate students' comprehension. This teacher's facilitation boosts students' ability to write and to think critically (Rimun & Yumarnamto, 2024). Similarly, the act of facilitating metacognitive reflection in EFL classes must be intensified to encompass all steps of the writing process, including the evaluation of the writing product (Knospe et al., 2016; Lee & Mak, 2018).

In the same strain, Rimun and Yumarnamto (2024) added that, through teachers' facilitation, students can gain more information about the writing process, monitor their progress, and develop reflective awareness. Consequently, educators as facilitators must prioritize communication and engagement with students to transform the classroom into a more dynamic environment. These students become more creative and can use their facilitative learning to overcome any language challenges (Suneetha, 2020).

4.2 Models of Metacognitive Thinking

In addition to being effective metacognitive facilitators, EFL teachers have to be skillful models of metacognitive thinking. Students as writers need a clear idea of how to proceed when using metacognitive writing strategies. Teachers can use a variety of techniques to model successful writing strategies for EFL students. These key techniques involve think-aloud demonstrations, peer and collaborative writing, and metacognitive questioning.

4.2.1 Think-Aloud Demonstrations

A think-aloud is a technique in which people verbalise their thoughts and feelings while doing a specific task (Chamot et al., 1999). For Flowers and Hayes (1980), *"it is simply to think-aloud while working like a person talking to herself"* (p.368). This technique can be highly productive, especially when incorporated into writing strategy instruction, as it provides evidence and richer data about the cognitive processes involved in writing (Gerova, 2022). Students' writing achievements can be impacted positively by teachers' think-alouds. However, "think-alouds are a complex skill for teachers to master" (Ness, 2014, p.458).

In-service training programmes may help teachers develop this technique, which

remains crucial in metacognitive writing instruction. Throughout its use, teachers share their thinking and make the writing process visible to students (Reading & Writing Haven, n.d.).

4.2.2 Peer and Collaborative Writing

Although many students prefer writing individually, whether at home or in the classroom, collaborative writing remains highly motivating. Such a technique is more practical for providing detailed and constructive feedback, reviewing, and evaluating students' collective writing productions (Harmer, 2001). Learning to write collaboratively creates an interactive environment that is generally monitored and guided by the teacher.

Collaborative writing activities develop higher writing quality and critical thinking skills (Moonma & Kaweera, 2021). By writing together, students observe others' minds at work, reveal their thinking strategies, and model their writing processes. This fact enables them to learn from each other under the teacher's guidance (Dale, 1997). In addition, it enhances their critical self-reflection and self-regulation (Fung, 2010).

4.2.3 Metacognitive Questioning

To monitor their writing effectively, students can use self-questioning to regulate their

understanding and solve their writing problems. According to Arianto and Hanif (2024), self-questioning “*functions as self-testing, which students constantly use to check on their understanding during learning*” (p.2). Metacognitive questioning can be practised via self-assessment checklists, peer-review prompts, and reflective journals.

4.2.3.1 Self-assessment Checklists

Self-assessment checklists are structured lists of specific criteria that students use to judge the quality of their own work and decide what revisions are needed (Andrade & Brooke, 2010). They play a vital role in metacognitive writing instruction by promoting students’ ability to plan, monitor, evaluate, and reflect on their writing process (Zimmerman, 2011).

Implementing self-assessment checklists in EFL courses entails teacher preparation and student instruction. Teachers must develop checklists that align with learning goals and are clear to learners (McMillan & Hearn, 2008).

4.2.3.2 Peer-review Prompts

Peer-review prompts are explicit, directed questions about some elements of writing that students use during peer feedback. This tool makes peer assessment more targeted, critical, and cognitively purposeful (Liu & Hansen Edwards, 2018).

Thus, fostering self-awareness and strategic regulation throughout the writing process (Bui & Kong, 2019). Self-regulated learners are those who are metacognitively, motivationally, and behaviourally active in their learning process. Organized peer-review prompts are pivotal tasks that enhance these behaviours in the writing process (Zimmerman & Schunk, 2001).

4.2.3.3 Reflective Journals

Reflective journals are written notes through which students intentionally report, examine, and understand their learning experiences. This technique helps students develop a deeper understanding and metacognitive awareness about their thinking and learning processes (Moon, 1999).

Involving reflective journals in metacognitive writing instruction promotes lifelong learning abilities. Training students to use reflective journals encourages them to transfer these competencies outside the classroom. This transfer ameliorates their academic writing commitment, strengthens their writing habits, and their critical thinking (Alt, 2022).

Using the three aforementioned tools, teachers can enhance students’ engagement and critical thinking. To sum up, the use of metacognitive questioning increases

students' self-regulation, self-confidence, and autonomy. To make this metacognitive technique clear and attainable, EFL teachers should focus on using it and explain to students how to use it through modelling to improve students' writing productions.

4.3 Scaffolders of Metacognitive Awareness

Being an explicit facilitator and a skillful modeller of metacognitive awareness does not always guarantee efficient students' engagement in the writing process. Most students need scaffolding to achieve better results and gain greater proficiency in writing. Scaffolding refers to *"many kinds of assistance that students receive as they move toward deeper understanding of what is being taught"* (Coyne et al., 2007, p.119). In line with the study by Rosenshine and Meister (1992), scaffolding is a temporary support provided by teachers to help students bridge the gap between what they can do unaided and what they can achieve with support, leading to better mastery and retention.

The concept of scaffolding is closely associated with Vygotsky's socio-cultural theory and his notion of the *Zone of Proximal Development (ZPD)*. According

to Vygotsky (1978), the ZPD refers to *"the distance between the actual developmental level as determined by independent problem solving and the level of potential development as determined through problem solving under adult guidance or in collaboration with more capable peers"* (p. 86). In other words, the ZPD delineates the space where learning occurs with appropriate support. The notion of *scaffolding*, later introduced by Wood, Bruner, and Ross (1976), builds upon this idea by describing the practical instructional support that teachers or peers provide to help learners progress within their ZPD. Being scaffolded by teachers also enhances learners' self-confidence, strengthens their writing commitment, and fosters greater self-reliance (Nourazar et al., 2022).

4.4 Teachers as Metacognitive Motivators

Teachers with high metacognitive motivation positively influence their students' engagement and performance throughout the writing process. Dörnyei (2001) proposed four components of motivational teaching practices in the L2 classroom: *"Creating the basic motivational conditions, generating initial motivation, maintaining and protecting motivation, and encouraging positive retrospective self-evaluation"* (p. 36).

Regarding the first element, Dörnyei (2001) suggested that teachers should adopt

appropriate teacher behaviour and create an enjoyable classroom environment. Accordingly, the teacher must be available and ready to help whenever asked. Shared trust and mutual respect with students are of great importance in demonstrating the teacher's engagement and care. To be effective writers, students need to be psychologically and physically relaxed in the classroom.

As a second component, Dörnyei (2001) advised teachers to generate students' initial motivation. In this case, the teacher's role is paramount, as he must promote positive language-related principles and perspectives among students. Besides, the teacher has to help students formulate explicit, relevant class goals through negotiation and perseverance to achieve successful task accomplishment.

Furthermore, Dörnyei (2001) emphasised teachers' roles in providing relevant teaching materials and fostering realistic students' beliefs to facilitate the writing process. Students feel more confident and motivated when the EFL teacher carefully selects teaching materials. In addition, the teacher can help students overcome unrealistic beliefs about their lack of effectiveness as writers by training them to confront writing challenges and

hindrances.

The third proponent is about motivation maintenance. According to Dörnyei (2001), the teacher must maintain students' motivation, especially when the learning task is difficult. Most students find writing challenging, and their motivation to write may collapse at any stage of the writing process. Therefore, making the writing process more enjoyable and stimulating may promote students' self-esteem, confidence, and reliance as high as possible, especially when writing collaboratively.

Finally, as a fourth component, Dörnyei (2001) advised teachers to train students to recognise their positive writing achievements and progress, and to associate a lack of effort with failure. Teachers can use constructive feedback and appropriately award rewards and grades to promote students' self-satisfaction when they perform effectively in writing. To conclude, by acting as a metacognitive motivator, the teacher can improve students' writing and enhance their productivity and self-satisfaction. Students' pride in their writing achievements can motivate their ongoing writing development.

4.5 Metacognitive Feedback Providers

The role of the teacher as a feedback provider in metacognitive writing instruction is essential for enhancing students' autonomy, critical thinking, and writing skills. Feedback is information given to students to narrow the gap between students' outcomes and the desired goals (Sadler, 1989). For Harmer (2001), feedback is not only planned to assess and evaluate students' tasks but also to help and instruct them on how to write effectively and improve their work.

A teacher as a feedback provider on students' written achievements can perform a variety of roles. He can be an 'examiner' who makes an objective evaluation of students' written performance. He can play the role of the 'audience' and respond to students' thoughts and perceptions. At the same time, he may operate as an 'assistant', providing students with aid whenever needed. In addition, he can be a

'resource' for students and offer help and guidance. Moreover, a teacher can act as an 'evaluator' and 'editor' to provide constructive feedback and to recognise students' pieces of writing, publishing them when possible (Tribble, 1996, as cited in Harmer, 2004).

Different feedback techniques can help students write more successfully and

improve their written work. Harmer (2001) suggested 'responding' and 'coding' as devices. The teacher may respond to students' work just by explaining how the piece of writing looks and how it should be improved. Such responses help students tailor their written productions without being frustrated. Coding is another technique that clarifies matters at various steps of the writing process. The use of symbols to correct wrong word order, verb tense, and punctuation or spelling mistakes makes teachers' corrections significantly beneficial.

In the same vein, Hedge (2000) proposed 'conferencing' and 'reformulation' as techniques to encourage students to plan, monitor, revise, and evaluate their written tasks. Conferencing is a device that students as writers can use at the beginning of the writing process to reflect on both content and organisation. Using questions in a checklist helps students greatly rearrange their first drafts. The second device is reformulation. It is done individually, either in pairs or collectively. According to Hedge (2000), this procedure provides students, as writers, with opportunities to compare their work with others and identify changes in vocabulary, grammar, accuracy, and relevance. Both techniques provide students with

informational and constructive feedback.

5. Limitations and Challenges

Despite its significant impact on students' writing skills, implementing metacognitive strategies in EFL classes remains challenging. Nevertheless, the literature review in this field identified several limitations. These include large classes, time constraints, teachers' insufficient proficiency to carry out metacognitive writing instruction effectively, students' lack of motivation and self-confidence, the quality of teaching materials, and other external factors.

First, EFL teachers face many difficulties in applying metacognitive strategies to writing instruction and in understanding how to implement them, particularly when teaching large classes. They do not have enough time to supervise students'

metacognitive reflection individually during writing activities. Additionally, teachers' experiences in teaching metacognitive strategies are limited. A significant number of teachers lack the strategies to address these issues and require support, just as their students do. Most studies emphasize the theoretical part and disregard the practical one (Muhammed et al., 2024).

Second, metacognitive writing instruction requires highly skilled teachers with well-developed metacognitive awareness. Implementing metacognitive strategies in the writing classroom is demanding. Any teacher's insufficient knowledge or training in metacognitive concepts may not give satisfactory results. Thus, teachers in metacognitive writing classrooms need to be familiar with metacognition to avoid less likely writing outcomes (Ramadhanti & Yanda, 2021).

Furthermore, individual differences in student readiness and motivation complicate teachers' efforts. Students' level of understanding plays a significant role in determining the efficacy of the metacognitive writing instruction (Annisa & Yunita, 2025). Most students struggle with planning, monitoring, and evaluating their writing because they lack training in metacognitive strategies. This deficiency leads to poor writing productions in terms of organization, clarity, and cohesion. In addition, students' inadequate knowledge of grammar and vocabulary hinders their ability to fully and correctly express their ideas (Muhammed et al., 2024). These language difficulties impede students' readiness to be metacognitively aware of the writing process.

Furthermore, Annisa and Yunita (2025) emphasize that the availability and quality of teaching materials used in the writing process can influence teachers' capacities to teach metacognitive strategies. Consequently, the effectiveness of the implementation of a metacognitive writing instruction does not only rely on the teacher's expertise, but also on the external factors that help create the appropriate teaching and learning environment.

To overcome teachers' limitations and challenges in metacognitive writing instruction, teachers must provide explicit instruction and model metacognitive strategies. They can break down complex writing tasks into manageable stages and verbalise thinking processes to make metacognition visible (Gilliam Writers Group, 2024). Further, constructive feedback is a critical tool that enables EFL teachers to evaluate both the

strengths and shortcomings of the writing process. Likewise, students can enhance their critical thinking skills and improve their writing tasks (Esfahani et al., 2023).

Managing time and class-size constraints is a challenging burden that most EFL teachers struggle with. To overcome such an issue, teachers can structure their

teaching to include more interactive, collaborative activities. Besides, the use of an e-portfolio may accentuate students' progress and autonomy. This digital tool supports formative assessment and allows teachers to completely tailor scaffolding to individual needs (William Writers Group, 2024).

6. CONCLUSION

In conclusion, this article has highlighted the crucial roles that EFL teachers play in developing students' metacognitive writing skills. By acting as facilitators, modellers, scaffolders, motivators, and feedback providers, teachers can help students become self-reliant writers and critical thinkers. Despite some persistent challenges, the reviewed literature consistently supports the integration of metacognitive strategies to enhance EFL students' writing performance. Therefore, providing EFL teachers with targeted training and continuous support in metacognitive writing instruction is essential for fostering sustainable improvements in students' writing development. It is recommended that future research explore innovative teacher-training models and classroom practices that further integrate metacognitive strategy instruction across diverse EFL writing contexts.

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